Botsitting Report

Founder Reports

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What AI Really Costs the People Who Use It

Workplace AI is usually measured by what it saves. Hours of manual work saved, drafts generated, tasks closed, etc. The time it demands in return gets less attention.

At Founder Reports, we surveyed 2,052 US employed adults who use AI at work at least once a week about the time they spend overseeing, checking, and fixing AI's output, how dependent they feel on their tools, and how they'd rate those tools as if they were employees. We also asked whether their employer accounts for the time they spend managing AI, and whether getting good work from AI takes more or less effort than training an entry-level hire.

With all of that data, we can look at individual workers and see both the hours they put into AI and how they feel about what they get from it. What we found is that AI isn't delivering for everyone equally. For about half of American workers who use AI, the net benefit is close to zero. And the workers who are most invested in AI, who spend the most time managing it and depend on it the most, are also its biggest advocates.

Key Findings

Half of workers who use AI at work say they'd get just as much done without it.
53.2% said that if their AI tools disappeared tomorrow, they'd get the same amount of work done or more. Only 13.6% said they'd get much less done.

For every worker who'd promote their AI, another would discipline it.
Asked what they'd do if they managed an employee who performed like their main AI tool, 17.1% would promote them, 12.5% would give them a warning, and 4.0% would fire them. The share who'd reward their AI (17.1%) and the share who'd discipline it (16.5%) are almost identical.

The more workers rely on AI, the more they appreciate it.
28.5% of workers who use AI multiple times a day would promote an employee performing like their AI, compared to just 8.0% of weekly users. The pattern is clearest at the extremes. Among respondents spending more than 10 hours a week on AI oversight, 32.9% would promote. Among weekly users, 22.2% would warn or fire.

Key Findings (continued)

Managing AI takes as much effort as training a new hire.

Among the 90.4% of respondents who have trained an entry-level employee, 60.0% said getting good work from AI takes at least as much effort. 33.1% said it takes more effort.

Most of the hours workers spend managing AI go uncounted by employers.

Among the 82.5% of respondents who spend any time overseeing, checking, or fixing AI's work, said their employer doesn't fully factor that time into their workload, or they are unsure.

Women report less dependence on AI than men.

59.0% of women said they'd get as much done without AI, compared to 47.4% of men. The difference holds even when comparing women and men at the same usage frequency.

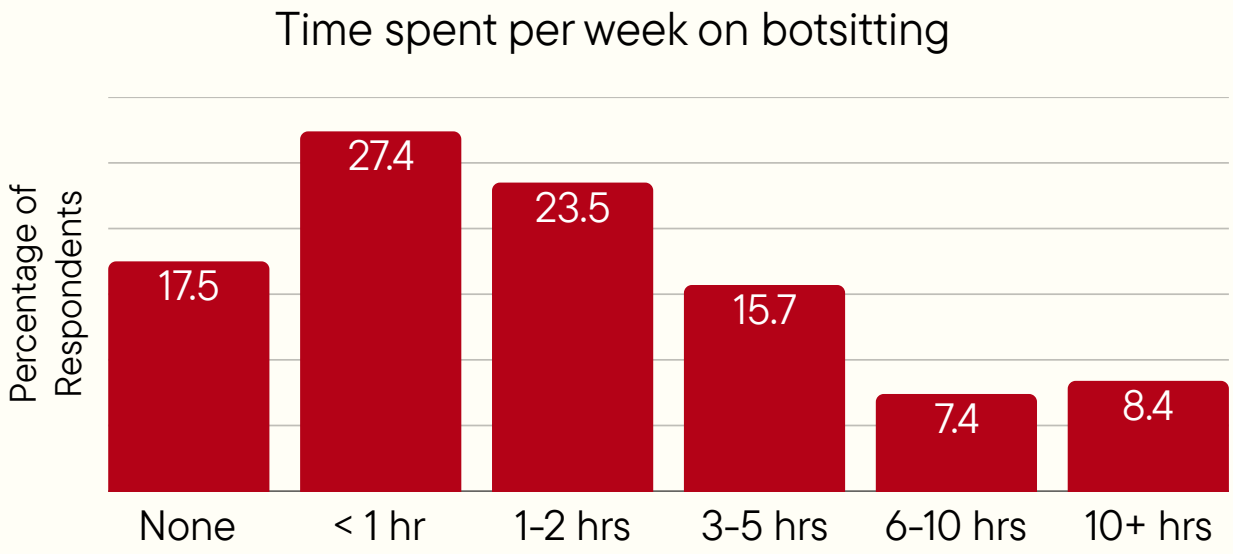
Managers spend more time managing AI than individual contributors.

40.7% of managers spend 3 or more hours a week on AI oversight, compared to 25.0% of individual contributors.

Section 1: How Much Time Workers Spend on AI Oversight

We asked respondents how much time they spend in a typical week training AI, overseeing it, checking its work, or fixing it.

82.5% of workers who use AI at least weekly spend some amount of time on this work. 31.6% spend 3 or more hours a week, and 15.8% spend 6 or more hours.



Hours spent on AI oversight scale sharply with the frequency of AI usage. Among respondents who use AI multiple times a day, 52.7% spend 3 or more hours a week on oversight, and 32.1% spend 6 or more. Among weekly users, those numbers drop to 17.6% and 4.4%.

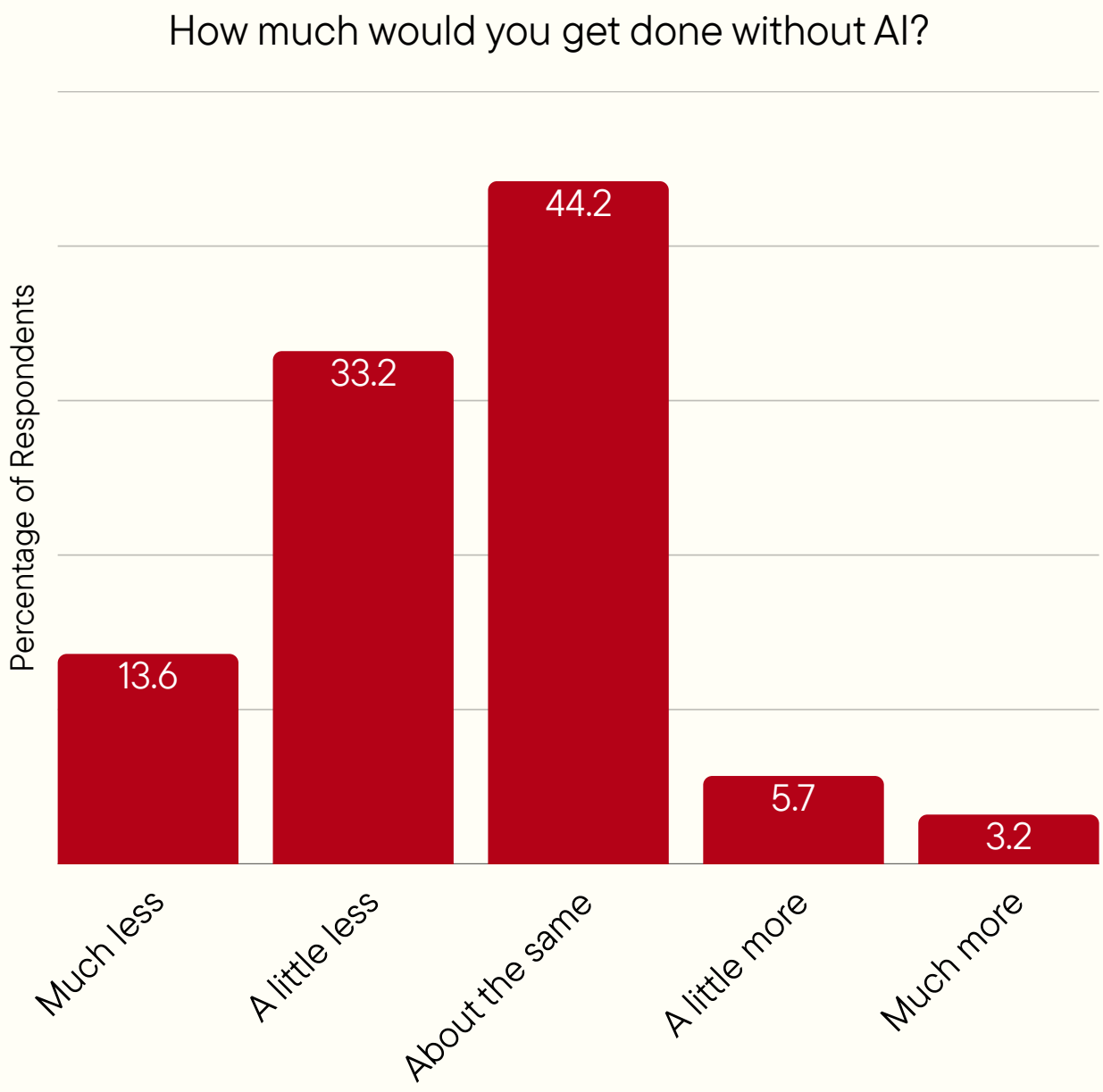
Among workers who use AI multiple times a day, more than 1 in 3 spends what amounts to most of a workday every week overseeing, checking, or fixing it.

The pattern also varies by role. 40.7% of managers and above spend 3 or more hours a week on AI oversight, compared to 25.0% of individual contributors. Managers aren't just reviewing their own AI output. They're also responsible for what their reports produce.

Section 2: Half Would Get as Much Done Without AI

We asked what would happen to respondents' output if their AI tools disappeared tomorrow.

53.2% said they'd get the same amount of work done or more. 8.9% said they'd actually get more done.



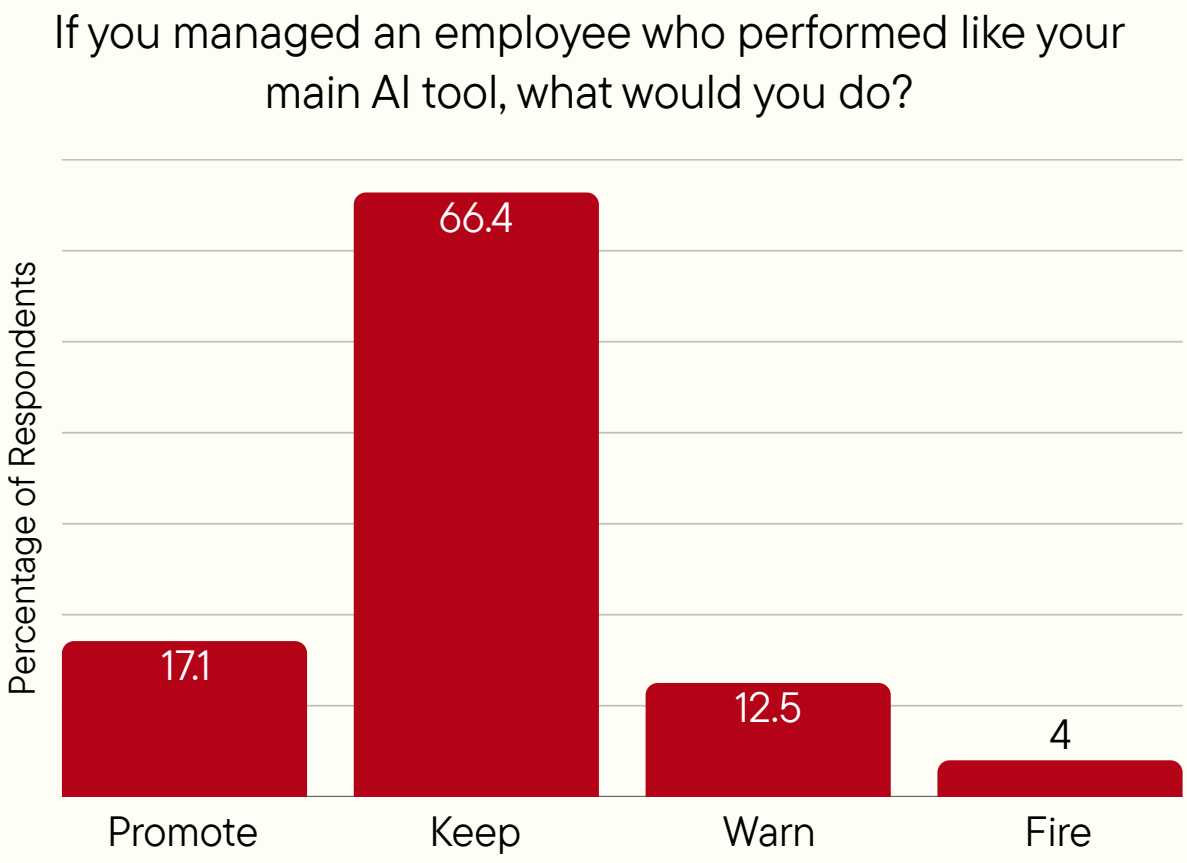
The pattern varies with how often people use AI, but the finding holds up even at the top of the usage scale.

AI usage	Would get the same or more done without AI
Once a week	67.2%
2-6 times a week	55.3%
Every day	47.3%
Multiple times a day	37.6%

Even among workers using AI multiple times a day, nearly 4 in 10 say they'd get the same amount done or more without it. For 24.9% of those multi-daily users, AI is clearly essential, as they say they'd get much less done without it. For the rest, the picture is murkier.

Section 3: AI's Performance Review

We asked what respondents would do if they managed an employee who performed like their main AI tool.



17.1% would promote the AI. 16.5% would discipline it with a warning or firing. Those shares are nearly identical. For every worker who sees their AI as high-performing, another sees it as underperforming enough to need corrective action.

Among respondents who said AI takes much more effort than training a new hire, 43.5% would warn or fire the AI. Among those for whom AI takes much less effort than training a new hire, 30.6% would promote it.

Section 4: The Dependence Divide

The most striking pattern in the data is how sharply attitudes toward AI split by usage. The more time workers spend with AI, the better they rate it, and the more dependent they are on it.

AI usage	Would promote	Would warn or fire	Would get much less done without AI
Once a week	8.0%	22.2%	6.9%
2-6 times a week	14.9%	16.8%	9.9%
Every day	20.6%	13.2%	16.4%
Multiple times a day	28.5%	12.0%	24.9%

The same pattern shows up when we sort by hours of oversight.

Weekly hours overseeing AI	Would promote
None	11.1%
Less than 1 hour	14.1%
1-2 hours	16.8%
3-5 hours	17.3%
6-10 hours	24.3%
More than 10 hours	32.9%

Among respondents who spend more than 10 hours a week on AI oversight, 32.9% would promote the AI and 41.0% say they'd get much less done without it. This is the group that has committed real time to making AI work, and it's also the group most convinced the time was well spent.

Looking at the groups directly makes the split clear. Among the 350 respondents who said they'd promote their AI, 59.7% use it daily or more, 42.9% spend 3 or more hours a week on oversight, and 32.3% say they'd get much less done without it. Among the 339 respondents who'd warn or fire their AI, 36.9% only use it once a week, 29.2% spend 3 or more hours on it, and just 5.0% say they'd get much less done without it.

Public conversation about workplace AI tends to treat workers as one audience. The data shows two populations. One has built workflows around AI and defends it strongly. The other uses AI occasionally, finds it adds roughly as much work as it saves, and would like it to perform better.

Section 5: AI Takes as Much Effort as Training a New Hire

We asked respondents to compare the effort involved in getting good work from AI to the effort of training an entry-level employee. 90.4% of respondents (1,856 people) had trained someone and could answer.

Effort compared to training a new hire	Share of respondents
Much more	9.9%
A little more	23.2%
About the same	26.9%
A little less	23.3%
Much less	16.7%

60.0% said getting good work from AI takes at least as much effort as training an employee. 33.1% said it takes more.

The result is remarkably consistent across groups. Among individual contributors who've trained someone, 62.3% said training AI takes as much or more time. Among managers, 58.4% said the same. Gen Z (61.0%), Millennials (60.8%), and Gen X (58.4%) land within 3 points of each other.

The comparison also predicts how workers rate their AI. Among respondents who said AI takes much more effort than training a new hire, 43.5% would warn or fire the AI. Among those who said it takes much less effort, 30.6% would promote it.

Companies cutting entry-level hiring on the assumption that AI replaces junior work are substituting one supervision task for another. Based on worker reports, the two take comparable effort.

Section 6: The Uncounted Hours

Workloads, deadlines, and performance expectations are usually set with the regular work in mind. We asked whether employers factor time spent managing AI into those calculations. The results are shown for the 1,693 respondents who said they spend any time at all on this work.

Does your employer factor time overseeing AI into your workload?	Share of those spending any time overseeing AI
Yes	38.2%
Partly	20.0%
No	34.5%
Not sure	7.3%

61.8% of respondents who spend any time managing AI say their employer doesn't fully account for that time, or they are unsure. For 34.5%, the oversight is treated as work on top of regular responsibilities.

Recognition rises steeply with hours spent overseeing AI.

Weekly hours overseeing AI	Employer factors time for AI oversight	Employer doesn't factor time for AI oversight
Less than 1 hour	24.4%	53.4%
1-2 hours	32.7%	33.5%
3-5 hours	46.4%	22.6%
6-10 hours	53.9%	17.1%
More than 10 hours	69.4%	13.3%

Heavy AI work is visible and often part of a job description, but employers often overlook light daily oversight. Workers who spend less than an hour a week managing AI are more than twice as likely to say that time goes uncounted as those who spend 10 or more hours.

Section 7: Managers Carry the Load

Managers and senior leaders spend substantially more time managing AI than individual contributors do. They're also more dependent on it and more likely to defend it.

Measure	**Managers and above** (n=884)	**Individual contributors** (n=1,014)
Spends 3+ hours a week on oversight	40.7%	25.0%
Would get the same or more done without AI	47.3%	57.5%
Would promote AI if it were an employee	20.1%	14.2%
Would warn or fire AI if it were an employee	16.0%	16.8%
Says employer accounts for time overseeing AI	40.7%	35.8%
Says employer doesn't count time for overseeing AI	30.9%	36.9%

Managers are more invested in AI. They spend more time with it, lean on it more heavily, and rate it more generously. Discipline rates are nearly identical across the two groups.

Managers also get slightly more credit. They're 5 points more likely to say their employer counts their AI time, and 6 points less likely to say it doesn't. For individual contributors spending any time on AI oversight, more say the work goes uncounted than counted.

Section 8: Sector Differences

How workers experience AI varies meaningfully by the kind of organization they work for.

Measure	**For-profit** (n=1,584)	**Government** (n=275)	**Non-profit** (n=193)
Spends 3+ hours a week on AI oversight	35.0%	20.4%	19.7%
Would get the same or more done without AI	51.3%	54.2%	66.8%
Would promote AI if it were an employee	18.7%	14.5%	7.3%
Would warn or fire	16.0%	14.9%	22.8%
Says employer doesn't count AI time (any-time users)	30.5%	46.4%	53.6%

Nonprofit workers would discipline their AI more than three times as often as they'd promote it (22.8% vs. 7.3%). At for-profit companies, those numbers look much different (18.7% promote vs. 16.0% discipline). Nonprofit workers are also the most likely to say they'd get as much done without AI (66.8%).

The recognition difference between for-profit workers and the public and nonprofit sectors is substantial. More than half of nonprofit workers who spend any time managing AI say their employer doesn't count it. The same is true for 46.4% of government workers but only 30.5% of for-profit workers.

Section 9: Sex and Age

By sex

Women and men differ meaningfully in how dependent they feel on AI, but not in how they rate it.

Women are 11.6 points more likely than men to say they'd get as much done without AI. The difference holds within usage levels. Among respondents who use AI multiple times a day, 44.3% of women said they'd get as much done without it, compared to 31.8% of men.

Promotion and discipline rates are nearly identical between women and men. Women aren't thinking worse of their AI, but they report less dependence on it.

Measure	**Women** (n=1,022)	**Men** (n=1,020)
Spends no time managing AI	20.8%	14.2%
Spends 3+ hours a week on AI oversight	27.3%	35.8%
Would get the same or more done without AI	59.0%	47.4%
Would get much less done without AI	11.9%	15.2%
Would promote AI if it were an employee	16.6%	17.5%
Would warn or fire	17.7%	15.3%

By age

Attitudes toward AI are mostly flat across generations. Gen Z (ages 18 to 27) is slightly more likely than Boomers (60 and older) to spend 3 or more hours a week on AI oversight (36.3% vs. 23.9%), but the questions about dependence, performance, and recognition show small differences across age groups.

Age group	3+ hours weekly on AI	Same or more done without AI	Would promote	Would warn or fire
Gen Z (18-27)	36.3%	52.3%	17.3%	22.6%
Millennial (28-43)	31.7%	53.5%	16.5%	15.7%
Gen X (44-59)	30.1%	54.1%	18.1%	18.1%
Boomer+ (60+)	23.9%	45.7%	16.3%	9.8%

The one meaningful spread is in discipline rates. Gen Z is more than twice as likely as Boomers to warn or fire their AI. Younger workers are the most willing to say their AI isn't passing.

Methodology

This study surveyed 2,052 US employed adults in October 2026, all of whom use AI at work at least once a week. The survey carried a neutral title ("Working With AI Tools: A Quick Survey") that made no reference to oversight, dependence, performance, or any other theme covered, so respondents weren't primed toward any of the study's findings before answering.

Respondents answered five questions, in order:

- In a typical week, how much time do you spend training AI, overseeing, checking, or fixing AI's work?
- Does your employer factor that time into your workload?
- If your AI tools disappeared tomorrow, how much work would you get done?
- If you managed an employee who performed like your main AI tool, what would you do?
- Compared with training an entry-level employee, how much effort does it take to train, oversee, check, and fix AI's work?

Measuring these in the same respondents allows cross-tabulation at the individual level. The relationship between hours spent, perceived productivity, and performance ratings is measured on the same workers rather than inferred by comparing separate datasets.

Screening data was used to filter for US residents, current employment, and weekly AI use at work, and to analyze subgroups by work role, employer type, employment status, age, and sex.

Sample Composition

Sex:

- Female: 49.8%
- Male: 50.2%

Age:

- 18 to 24: 6.7%
- 25 to 34: 32.7%
- 35 to 44: 31.6%
- 45 to 54: 19.1%
- 55 and older: 9.9%

Mean age is 39.0, and the median is 37. The age range is 18 to 81.

Methodology (continued)

Employment status:

- Full-time: 82.2%
- Part-time: 17.8%

AI usage at work:

- Once a week: 27.5%
- 2 to 6 times a week: 31.4%
- Every day: 19.6%
- Multiple times a day: 21.5%

Work role:

- Individual contributor / Non-manager: 49.4%
- Manager: 26.4%
- Senior manager: 7.0%
- Director / Associate director: 5.4%
- None of the above or unspecified: 7.5%
- Vice president: 1.7%
- CEO or C-suite executive: 1.2%
- Owner: 0.8%
- President: 0.5%
- Partner: 0.2%

Employer type:

- For-profit company: 77.2%
- Non-profit, tax-exempt, or charitable organization: 9.4%
- State government: 5.5%
- Local government: 4.9%
- Federal government: 3.0%

Self-employed workers were excluded from this study because several questions refer to an employer or a workload set by someone else.

Limitations

This is a cross-sectional snapshot. It establishes strong associations between AI usage, perceived productivity, and performance ratings rather than proving one causes another. The dependence divide in particular is a correlation measured at a single point in time, and causation plausibly runs in both directions. Workers who are already enthusiastic about AI may use it more and defend it more, while workers who have invested the most time may rationalize that investment positively.

The sample consists of workers who already use AI at work at least weekly. The results describe how this population experiences AI rather than how all American workers do. Workers who have declined to adopt AI altogether aren't represented here.

All five questions rely on self-reporting. Estimates of time spent and output lost are the respondents' own, not observed measurements. Reported hours should be read as how workers perceive the time, which is itself meaningful for how they'll make further decisions about AI, but may not match a stopwatch.

Two subgroups carry small samples and are reported as directional rather than precise. The CEO or C-suite category has 25 respondents, and the Boomer age group has 92 respondents.

The sample is roughly balanced by sex (50.2% male, 49.8% female) and includes a smaller share of part-time workers than the national workforce.

About This Research

This report was produced by Founder Reports (founderreports.com), a business-focused publication covering entrepreneurship and workplace trends through original research, data analysis, and founder interviews.

The survey was conducted in October 2026. All respondents were screened for US residency, current employment with an outside organization, and weekly AI use at work. The data has been cleaned to remove incomplete responses, consent-revoked records, and submissions completed in under 20 seconds.

For questions about this research, interview requests, or permission to reproduce charts, contact Marc Shorb, info@founderreports.com.